The Post-Degree Learning Refusal in Computer Science Students:
A Brief Technical Note on the "Any-Work" Event Horizon

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Abstract

This short faux-academic note models a familiar phenomenon among computer science students: after three to four years of continuous learning, exams, projects, and interview preparation, many graduates do not become more excited to learn. They become tired of learning as a survival condition. At the same time, the entry-level market sends contradictory signals: long-run software demand remains strong, but new graduates experience AI disruption, budget caution, rejection loops, and rising expectations. The result is the *Any-Work Event Horizon*: a psychological threshold where the student stops asking "what should I master next?" and starts asking "what job will accept me first?" The paper introduces a simple model, not as a clinical diagnosis or labor-market forecast, but as a compact explanation of why capable students may appear unmotivated exactly after completing an education designed to prepare them.

1 Introduction

The traditional story says that a CS degree converts a beginner into an employable developer. The contemporary student often receives a stranger message: *finish the degree, build side projects, solve LeetCode, learn cloud, learn AI tools, write a better CV, apply everywhere, then explain why you have no production experience.* The contradiction is not merely economic. It is cognitive: the student is asked to remain in permanent training mode after years of already being evaluated.

This note names the resulting state **post-degree learning refusal**. It does not mean laziness. It means that learning has been psychologically reclassified from curiosity into cost. The student still wants competence, income, dignity, and progress. What collapses is the belief that one more course, framework, certificate, or tutorial will necessarily move them closer to work.

2 Market Signals and Student Perception

The labor market is not uniformly hopeless. For example, the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics projects 15% growth for software developers, QA analysts, and testers from 2024 to 2034, and NACE reported a planned 7.3% increase in hiring for the college Class of 2025 compared with the Class of 2024 [1, 2]. Yet this optimism coexists with a harsher subjective reality: many students see fewer clear junior paths, longer interview funnels, and employers preferring candidates who already look mid-level.

AI amplifies the ambiguity. Stack Overflow's 2025 survey reports that 84% of respondents use or plan to use AI tools in development, while 15% see AI as a job threat and 21.3% are unsure [3, 4]. Thus, students do not simply fear unemployment; they fear that the definition of "entry-level developer" is moving while they are still trying to reach it.

3 A Minimal Model

Let t denote years since beginning the CS degree. Define:

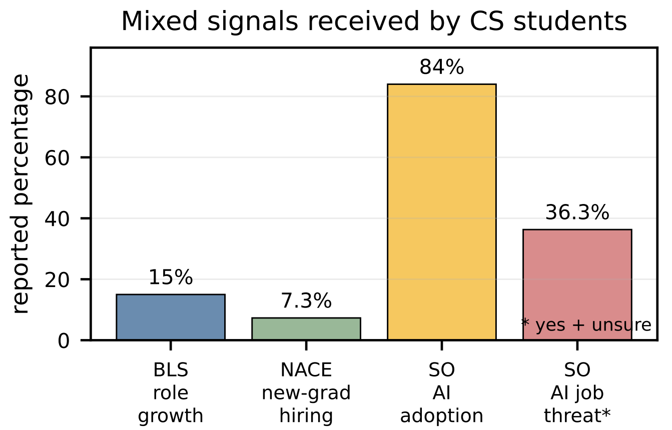

Figure 1: The student receives optimistic macro-signals and threatening micro-signals at the same time. Percentages are drawn from cited public sources; categories are not directly comparable but show the mixed informational environment.

- $K(t)$: accumulated technical skill,
- $F(t)$: educational fatigue,
- $U(t)$: perceived market uncertainty,
- $R(t)$: rejection feedback from applications/interviews,
- $L(t)$: willingness to learn voluntarily.

A compact behavioral model is

$$L(t) = L_0 + \delta W(t) - \alpha F(t) - \beta U(t) - \gamma R(t), \tag{1}$$

where $W(t)$ represents visible wins: paid responsibility, mentorship, small shipped projects, or genuine interview progress. The important term is not $K(t)$. Skill can rise while learning appetite falls. That is the paradox: the student becomes more capable and less willing to continue the same educational loop.

The **Any-Work Event Horizon** occurs when

$$F(t) + U(t) + R(t) > W(t) + H(t), \tag{2}$$

where $H(t)$ is hope: the belief that effort maps to opportunity. Past this threshold, the rational-sounding strategy becomes: accept almost any relevant work, reduce uncertainty, and stop expanding the syllabus of the self.

4 The Phenomenon

Post-degree learning refusal has several observable symptoms:

- **Tutorial saturation**: the student can no longer tolerate another "build this app in 10 hours" promise.
- **Portfolio distrust**: projects feel fake unless someone pays for them or uses them.
- **Any-work reflex**: QA, support, data labeling, tutoring, IT helpdesk, research assistant work, or backend maintenance may feel more attractive than another unpaid preparation cycle.
- **Identity compression**: after years of saying "I am becoming a software engineer," the student starts saying "I just need work."

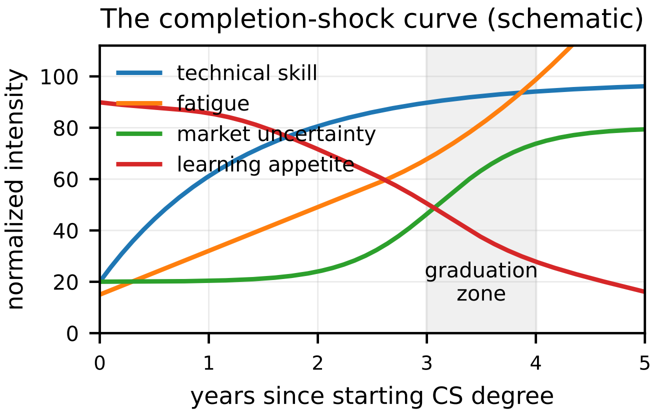

Figure 2: Schematic model: skill continues increasing, but fatigue and uncertainty rise near graduation. The refusal is not anti-learning; it is a reaction to learning without a visible payoff.

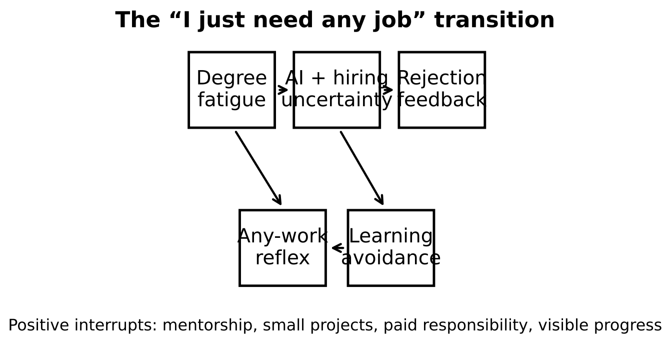

Figure 3: A simple causal sketch. The loop can be interrupted when students obtain visible progress, mentorship, or paid responsibility rather than more abstract advice.

The phenomenon is intensified by a hidden mismatch. Universities reward solvable problems with known rubrics. Hiring rewards ambiguous signals: referrals, timing, communication, portfolio credibility, and proof that one can operate inside a messy team. The student graduates from a system where effort is legible into a system where effort is noisy.

5 Discussion

The model explains why telling exhausted students to "just keep learning" can fail. The advice is technically correct and psychologically incomplete. More learning helps only if it changes the student's opportunity surface. Otherwise, every new topic feels like a postponement of adulthood.

A better intervention is not infinite motivation. It is **evidence of traction**. A small paid task, a research assistant role, a real user, a merged pull request, or a serious mentor can restore $W(t)$ in Eq. 1. The student does not need to believe that the market is easy. They need proof that action can still produce movement.

The paper's satirical claim is therefore serious: the student is not broken. The pipeline is. We trained students for years to optimize grades, then asked them to optimize uncertainty. We made learning the entrance fee to dignity, and then became surprised when dignity became more urgent than learning.

6 Conclusion

The post-degree CS student may look like someone who has stopped caring. A more accurate reading is that they have reached the edge of a long educational tunnel and discovered that the exit is another tunnel, except this one has no syllabus. The *Any-Work Event Horizon* names the moment when stability becomes more valuable than optimization. The antidote is not another motivational speech; it is concrete contact with real work, real feedback, and real responsibility.

References

[1] U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics. *Software Developers, Quality Assurance Analysts, and Testers: Occupational Outlook Handbook*. 2024-2034 projection. `https://www.bls.gov/ooh/computer-and-information-technology/software-developers.htm`

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[3] Stack Overflow. *2025 Developer Survey: AI*. `https://survey.stackoverflow.co/2025/ai`

[4] Stack Overflow. *2025 Developer Survey: Work*. `https://survey.stackoverflow.co/2025/work`